Draft — pending clinical review

Fever and rash in children

How to care for your child at home, protect others — and know when to get help

The 5 things to remember

- Most rashes with fever are caused by viruses and get better on their own.
- Do the **glass test**. If the spots do not fade under a glass, **go to the emergency department now**.
- For fever, use **paracetamol**. **Never give aspirin** to children. Do not give ibuprofen for chickenpox.
- Keep your child at home and **away from pregnant women and newborn babies** until your doctor says it is safe.
- Check your child has had **all their vaccines**, including two doses of MMR.

The glass test

Press the side of a clear glass firmly on the spots. If you can still see the spots through the glass, this can be a sign of a serious infection called meningococcal disease (meningitis). Go to the emergency department or call 997 straight away. On darker skin, check the palms, soles and inside the eyelids.

Common rashes in children

Illness	What you may see	Stay off nursery or school
Measles	High fever, cough, runny nose, red eyes, then a blotchy rash from the face down	4 days from the start of the rash
Chickenpox	Itchy spots that turn into blisters, then scabs	Until all spots have scabbed (about 5 days)
Scarlet fever	Sore throat, red rough “sandpaper” rash, red tongue	24 hours after starting antibiotics
Impetigo	Sores with yellow-brown crusts, often around the nose and mouth	Until crusted, or 2 days after starting antibiotics
Slapped cheek (fifth disease)	Bright red cheeks, then a lacy rash on arms and legs	No need once the rash appears
Roseola	High fever for 3–5 days, then a pink rash as the fever goes	No need once well
Hand, foot and mouth	Mouth ulcers and small blisters on hands and feet	No need if well enough

Caring for your child at home

- Give **small drinks often** — water, milk or breast milk. Cold drinks help a sore mouth.
- Use **paracetamol** if your child is uncomfortable. Follow the dose on the pack for their age or weight.
- Dress your child in light clothes. For itchy spots, use calamine lotion and keep nails short.
- Wash hands often and use a separate towel. Finish all the antibiotic if your doctor gives one.

Protect others

- **Pregnant women** who have been near your child should call their doctor today — some rashes can harm an unborn baby.
- Keep your child away from **newborn babies** and anyone with **weak immunity** (for example, on cancer treatment or steroids).
- **Call the clinic before you come**, so staff can keep other patients safe in the waiting room.

Get help now — call 997 or go to the emergency department if your child:

- Has spots that do **not fade** with the glass test.
- Is very sleepy, hard to wake, confused, or floppy.
- Has a fit (seizure), a stiff neck, or fast or difficult breathing.
- Has cold hands and feet with a high fever, or is not passing urine.
- Is **under 3 months old** with a temperature of 38 °C or more.

See your doctor today if:

- The fever lasts **5 days or more**, especially with red eyes, red lips or swollen hands and feet.
- Your child is not drinking enough, or a spot becomes very red, swollen or painful.
- Your child has **sickle cell disease** or weak immunity and becomes pale or tired.
- You live in or visited an area with **dengue** and your child has fever with body pain — do not give ibuprofen.

My plan

What the doctor thinks my child has: _____

Medicine and dose: _____

Back to school on: _____

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This leaflet gives general information. It does not replace advice from your own doctor, who knows your health. Bring it to your next visit and ask about anything that is unclear. Written with AI assistance, checked by the medical editor, and still under review with colleagues.

Last updated: November 2026 · **Next review:** November 2027, or sooner if guidance changes

Sources:

1. CDC. Isolation precautions guideline, Appendix A: type and duration of precautions (2007, updated 2023)
2. UK Health Security Agency. Health protection in children and young people's settings — exclusion table (updated September 2026)
3. NICE. Fever in under 5s (NG143); Meningitis and meningococcal disease (NG240, 2024); Impetigo (NG153)
4. American Academy of Pediatrics. Red Book 2024–2027
5. Ministry of Health, Saudi Arabia. National immunization schedule (Sehhaty)